



**The Open Group® Professional
Certification Program**

**Conformance Requirements for the
Architect Profession (Open CA)**

Version 4.0
June 2023

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**The Open Group® Professional Certification Program:
Conformance Requirements for the Architect Profession (Open CA)**

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1. Introduction

The Open Group Professional Certification Program (the Program) is designed to validate the existence of those qualities and skills in a professional that enable the effective development, implementation, and operation of Business or IT-related specializations. The Program is skills and experience-based and goes beyond validating the mastery of any specific knowledge base.

The Program covers multiple Professions. This document is for the Architect Profession, which leads to certification as an Open Certified Architect (Open CA).

The Open Group supports two different routes to certification:

- The first route is Direct Certification by The Open Group
- The second route is Indirect Certification through third-party programs accredited by The Open Group

The Conformance Requirements for each of the Professions in the Program apply equally to Direct and Indirect Certification.

This document is intended for individuals who wish to pursue Direct Certification in the Architect Profession as Open Certified Architects, and for organizations that wish to run Accredited Certification Programs internally.

1.1 Conformance Requirements

This document defines the requirements for certification as an Open Certified Architect (Open CA), and may also be used as the foundation of an Architect Profession framework.

These Conformance Requirements define those qualities and skills in a professional that enable the effective practice of Business, Digital, Enterprise, and Solution Architecture. The requirements are skills and experience-based and do not define or require any specific knowledge base.

The document may be used on its own or, in conjunction with other related documents from The Open Group, as a guide for individual career development as well as a framework for Architect Profession programs within members of The Open Group and other public and private sector organizations. The Conformance Requirements are designed to be flexible and extensible so that the framework may be adapted and extended to meet the needs of any industry, country, or organization.

1.2 Key Documents

The Architect Profession is based upon three key documents:

- The Open Group Professional Certification Program Certification Policy, which sets out the policies and processes by which an architect may achieve certification
- The Open Group Professional Certification Program Conformance Requirements for the Architect Profession (Open CA) (this document), in which are documented the skills and experience that an architect must possess to achieve certification
- The Open Group Professional Certification Program Configuration Document for the Architect Profession (Open CA), which outlines the specific certification policies and processes for the Architect Profession

Practical information about the certification process is available through the Open Professions FAQ and other Open Professions documentation on the Certification Authority's website.

1.3 Levels of Certification

The Program recognizes three levels of certification:

- Level 1: A professional who is able to perform with assistance/supervision with a wide range of appropriate skills as a contributing professional.
- Level 2: A professional who is able to perform independently and take responsibility for delivery of solutions as lead professional.
- Level 3: A professional who has significant breadth and depth of impact on the business through the application of their Profession.

Candidates applying for certification at Level 3 are required either to be certified at Level 2, or to have met the Level 2 Conformance Requirements at some time in the past.

1.4 This Document

This document is a major revision to the Open CA Conformance Requirements. Every effort has been made to ensure that anyone meeting the previous versions of the Open CA Conformance Requirements will also meet the requirements in Version 4.0.

1.5 Migration and Change History

This section details changes made to the Open CA Conformance Requirements.

Version No.	Date	Change
1.0	January 2011	First publication. Combines Levels 1 through 3.
1.0.1	July 2011	Supersedes Version 1.0. Contains cosmetic changes to Version 1.0 only for the change in Program name.
1.1	May 2014	Addition of Part 3 containing the Conformance Requirements for the Enterprise Architect Career Path Category at Levels 1 and 2. Addition of Part 4 containing the Conformance Requirements for the Business Architect, previously published as an Addendum (X120) in November 2012. Addition of Part 5, merging sections on Recognition Requirements for Methods, including text added following PR0055.
2.0	June 2016	Revision to Conformance Requirements to harmonize the requirements for Enterprise, Business, and IT Architecture disciplines, and to use common language to describe skills that are common to the other professional certification programs defined by The Open Group.
3.0	June 2018	Document title change to The Open Group® Professional Certification Program Conformance Requirements for the Architect Profession (Open CA). Renamed IT Architecture discipline to Solution Architecture. Addition of the Level 3 Conformance Requirements. Changed wording to incorporate recommended text from Problem Report 68 which corrects wording in EC01 and from Problem Report 69 which clarifies the validity period for Experience Profiles.

Version No.	Date	Change
3.1	December 2018	Includes implementation of the decision across all professions that EXP criteria apply to each Experience Milestone Application and EC criteria apply only to the application for certification.
4.0	February 2021	Includes the Digital Architecture discipline, and application of PR68, PR69, PR79, PR80, and PR87.
4.0 (Updated)	June 2023	Correction of errors in the application of the PRs listed above.

2. Architect Roles and Responsibilities (Informative)

The Program defines professional Architecture disciplines: Business Architecture, Digital Architecture, Enterprise Architecture, and Solution Architecture.

An Architect according to the Open Professions Program defines solutions to client business problems through the reasoned application of capabilities and/or technology.

Those solutions are documented as architectures and can include systems, applications, capabilities, and process components. They may also involve the application and integration of a broad variety of products, technologies, and services; various systems and applications architectures; and diverse hardware and software components.

2.1 Characteristics of the Architect

The key skill and contribution Architects bring to their pursuits is the creation of architectures that address business problems.

Effective Architects typically possess and exhibit the following:

Skills and experience producing architectures	Architects develop architectures; the definition of the structures of a solution to a business problem. In order to accomplish this they must be proficient at the techniques that go into the formulation of architectures, including requirements discovery and analysis, application of abstraction, formulation of solution context, identification and assessment of alternative solutions, technology selection, and architectural configuration.
Appropriate skills and experience, including architectural breadth	Architects require practical skills and experience with many business, application, and infrastructure solutions, techniques, technologies, and services. While often relying on other professionals with specialized skills for the construction, implementation, and operational aspects of solution delivery in many of these areas, the Architect must have broad enough skills and experience to be able to successfully create appropriate solutions of heterogeneous components.
Disciplined, method-driven execution	The Architect uses formal methods to guide and drive the development of solutions, the management of their work, and the production of their deliverables.
Full lifecycle experience	In the development of architectures that address business problems, the Architect's work is primarily performed at the front end of the solution lifecycle. Full lifecycle experience – in particular, the knowledge and appreciation of the construction, implementation, and management aspects of the solution lifecycle – enables the Architect to produce solution designs that are truly viable and that can be successfully implemented, operated, and managed.
Leadership	An effective Architect is a leader, providing knowledge, technical, and team leadership skills in their work, to their clients, and for their teams.

Strong personal and professional skills	The Architect must have a high level of communications, consulting, and client relationship skills. The Architect must be able to clearly communicate complex technical and business concepts, both to clients (internal or external) and to team members, and to negotiate change. Problem-solving of client business and technical issues is a key role of the Architect, and he or she must be capable of effectively identifying and framing problems, leading the collection of elements of information, and integrating this information to produce timely and well-considered decisions.
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2.2 Types of Architects – Architecture Disciplines

The Open Group recognizes that Open Certified Architects will be expected to demonstrate a higher level of proficiency in one of several areas of architecture focus or discipline that reflect organizational requirements and industry views, in addition to the fundamental skills defined in this Conformance Requirements document. The types and requirements of the Open Certified Architect disciplines will evolve with the needs of the industry and will be updated accordingly.

Open CA certification currently recognizes four architecture disciplines: Business, Digital, Enterprise, and Solution Architecture. To achieve certification in a discipline, Candidates must document discipline-specific evidence for applicable Conformance Requirements. To achieve certification in Business or Digital Architecture conformance with additional discipline-specific skills is also required.

Throughout the remainder of the document the term <discipline-specific> is intended to be substituted by Business Architecture, Digital Architecture, Enterprise Architecture, or Solution Architecture, as applicable.

Wherever the word “client” appears in this document it is intended to be read as meaning either an internal (in-house) client, or an external client as part of a consulting engagement.

3. Level 1 and Level 2 Conformance Requirements (Normative)

The Conformance Requirements for a Level 1 or Level 2 Open Certified Architect are broken down as follows:

- Core Basic skills
- Architecture Basic skills
- Discipline skills
- Experience Profile requirements
- Professional Development requirements
- Community Contribution requirements
- Experience requirements

3.1 Skill Levels

For the Core Basic skills, Architecture Basic skills, and Discipline skills, Candidates must meet or exceed the minimum skill level defined for each of the skills.

Table 1 lists the definition of skill levels and associated proficiency levels.

Table 1: Skill Level Definitions

Skill Level	Proficiency	Experience
Limited	Limited or no knowledge	None
General	General conceptual knowledge only	Limited – read about it, some education
Applied	Applied knowledge	Performs with supervision or mentoring
Deep	In-depth knowledge	Mastered the current state-of-the-art and is able to perform without supervision
Expert	Expert knowledge	Advances the state-of-the-art

3.2 Core Basic Skills

Table 2 lists the Core Basic skills for Level 1 and Level 2.

To achieve certification Candidates must be able to document that they have demonstrated these skills at the required level (or higher) repeatedly and successfully.

Table 2: Core Basic Skills for Level 1 and Level 2

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 1	Skill Level 2
CBS01	Communicate in Writing	Good written communication of <discipline-specific> topics, including the use of proper grammar, spelling, document organization, clarity, and use of appropriate content for the audience to meet its purpose.	Open Certified professionals need to be able to effectively communicate their <discipline-specific> topics – topics that are critical for the continuation of the work, such as architectural decisions and design decisions.	Applied	Deep
CBS02	Communicate Verbally	Good verbal communication, with responsiveness to questions, ability to stay on subject, use of good feedback, and follow-up questions, etc., leading to effective two-way communication. Culturally-appropriate body language is expected in face-to-face meetings and video conferencing.	Open Certified professionals need to be able to effectively communicate their <discipline-specific> topics – topics that are critical for the continuation of the work, such as architectural decisions and design decisions.	Applied	Deep
CBS03	Influential Leadership	Given a scope of <discipline-specific> work to be accomplished, formulate direction, influence the shape of the work, and lead or guide a team and its members to collaborate in performing the work to completion.	Open Certified professionals must be able to influence and lead/guide teams to collaborate in producing results that meet the intended purpose of the <discipline-specific> work effort. For example, influencing and challenging team members to consider and accommodate broader concepts.	Applied	Deep

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 1	Skill Level 2
CBS04	Mediate Equitable Solutions	Given a conflict that jeopardizes the integrity of the solution, mediate differing stakeholder opinions to arrive at equitable resolutions that ensure successful and stable outcomes.	Open Certified professionals must be capable of maintaining the integrity of their work products while simultaneously serving the needs of multiple stakeholders of diverse needs.	Applied	Deep
CBS05	Understand Business Aspects	Understand the stakeholders' business needs, how they relate to their business and mission, and to the <discipline-specific> activities.	Open Certified professionals must have business insight into how <discipline-specific> activities and work products serve the business needs of a variety of stakeholders and how they relate to the larger business context.	Applied	Deep
CBS06	Develop Solutions	Given one or more business or technical requirements, create the <discipline-specific> structures of a system or solution that can be validated to meet those requirements while adhering to business and/or technical constraints.	Open Certified professionals must be skillful in creating solutions that can be demonstrated to solve problems while adhering to business and/or technical constraints.	Applied	Deep
CBS07	Manage Discipline-specific Risks within a Project/Work Effort	Given a project/work effort, identify those elements that put the integrity of the <discipline-specific> aspects of the effort at risk and manage them through to completion as agreed by the appropriate decision-maker(s).	Open Certified professionals must be able to work closely with stakeholders to address issues in projects/work efforts that put their work at risk. They must be able to communicate the likelihood and the impact of the risks and come to agreement with the appropriate decision-maker(s) about mitigation.	Applied	Deep

3.3 Architecture Basic Skills

Table 3 lists the Architecture Basic skills for Level 1 and Level 2.

To achieve certification Candidates must be able to document that they have demonstrated these skills at the required level (or higher) repeatedly and successfully.

Table 3: Architecture Basic Skills for Level 1 and Level 2

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 1	Skill Level 2
ABS01	Architectural Modeling	Select, employ, and construct appropriate models in order to make inferences, and to justify the design of solutions or to answer architectural questions.	Open Certified Architects must be able to use modeling techniques to determine breadth and depth of the solution and, where applicable, its size, and to validate that the proposed architecture addresses the business needs.	Applied	Deep
ABS02	Perform Solution Assessments	Given a solution and the underlying business needs that drove its development, assess the technical integrity, coherence, and risks inherent in that solution in such a way that the recommendations and findings are appropriate and actionable. Assessment techniques may include risk assessment, security assessment, agility assessment, capacity assessment, and others as appropriate.	Open Certified Architects must be able to evaluate the integrity and coherence of their solutions, or the solutions of others, and identify the feasibility and risks of their implementation within the intended context.	Applied	Deep
ABS03	Apply Standards	Given project requirements that call for or would benefit from the use of business, technology, or other standards, identify/establish/create, implement, and enforce appropriate standards in the solution to meet those requirements. Standards may be <i>de jure</i> , <i>de facto</i> , or company/client-defined.	Open Certified Architects must be able to recognize the benefits of applying relevant standards in a solution and proactively secure these standards in the creation and implementation of the solution.	Applied	Deep

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 1	Skill Level 2
ABS04	Establish Vision	Given requirements and a list of stakeholders, explain the present and future state (vision) and how to achieve it, by identifying approaches, tools, techniques, and appropriate solutions so that stakeholders accept the choices and agree with the rationale.	Open Certified Architects must be able to establish a vision that meets business requirements and is agreed to by stakeholders.	Applied	Deep
ABS05	No longer applicable.				
ABS06	Apply Architecture Methods	Given a work effort, adapt, apply, and enforce the use of a method that meets the method recognition criteria documented on the Open CA website to successfully create architectural work products that meet the requirements of the work effort. Candidates are not required to have used more than one recognized method.	Open Certified Architects must demonstrate the ability to adapt and follow a recognized method to help ensure repeatability of delivery and success. The use of methods usually requires selection of work products and processes (adaptation). Methods are seldom adopted without change.	Applied	Deep
ABS07	Define Solutions to Functional and Non-functional Requirements	Given <discipline-specific> functional and non-functional requirements, define a <discipline-specific> solution that meets the stated requirements using the organization's and industry standard procedures and tools.	Open Certified Architects must demonstrate their ability to work with requirements using standard procedures and tools from the organization and/or industry such that the solution characteristics meet the given functional and non-functional requirements.	Applied	Deep
ABS08	Establish Architectural Decisions	Determine, document, and communicate architectural decisions to support and rationalize the design of the solution to achieve understanding and commitment from stakeholders.	Open Certified Architects must be able to establish their architectural decisions by communicating them to stakeholders so as to achieve their understanding and commitment.	Applied	Deep

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 1	Skill Level 2
ABS09	No longer applicable.				
ABS10	Elicit and Manage Stakeholder Requirements	Given approved business goals, objectives, and constraints, validate and/or elicit them with/from stakeholders, and capture, clarify, refine, detail, prioritize, and ensure completeness of functional and non-functional requirements.	Open Certified Architects need to be able to take business goals, objectives, and constraints, and to define the functional and non-functional requirements that can meet them. They also need to be able to identify stakeholders and ensure that the requirements they have identified meet their needs.	Applied	Deep
ABS11	Provide Reliable Advice	Use knowledge of technologies, business trends, legislation, methods, or techniques to provide reliable advice to clients and/or teams.	Open Certified Architects need to be seen as trusted advisors, able to give reliable advice in line with current relevant best practices.	Applied	Deep
ABS12	Define Transitions	Given <discipline-specific> current and future states, define realizable plans through which the transition from the current to the future state can be managed.	Open Certified Architects need to be responsible for the transition approach through which their architectures can be realized in practice.	General	Applied

3.4 Discipline Skills

Table 4, Table 5, and Table 6 list the Discipline skills applicable to Level 1 and Level 2.

To achieve certification Candidates must be able to document that they have demonstrated the skills for their chosen discipline at the required level (or higher) repeatedly and successfully.

Discipline skills applicable to the Business Architect, Enterprise Architect, and Solution Architect are defined in Table 4.

Table 4: Discipline Skills – Business Architect, Enterprise Architect, and Solution Architect for Level 1 and Level 2

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 1	Skill Level 2
ADS01	Validate Solution Architectures	Given validation criteria, define and execute strategies and plans for determining that the realized solution satisfies the documented architecture and identifying any variances.	Open Certified Architects must be able to determine whether a realized solution conforms to the documented architecture and whether there are any variances.	Applied	Deep

Discipline skills applicable to the Business Architect are defined in Table 5.

Table 5: Discipline Skills – Business Architect for Level 1 and Level 2

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 1	Skill Level 2
BAS01	Discover Business Goals, Objectives, and Constraints	Engage with business stakeholders to discover, influence, and document the goals, objectives, or strategic vision of a business, within the relevant business context and the scope of the engagement.	In addition to the elicitation and management of stakeholder requirements, Business Architects need to be able to discover and influence goals, objectives, or strategic vision of a business.	Applied	Deep
BAS02	Derive, Analyze, and Assess Value Drivers	The ability to derive, analyze, and assess value drivers, critical success factors, and key performance indicators for an industry or a specific organization, and relate them to the strategic business goals and objectives.	Business Architects should have the ability to critically analyze the business value drivers, how they interrelate, and how they serve the strategic business goals and objectives.	Applied	Deep

Discipline skills applicable to the Digital Architect are defined in Table 6.

Table 6: Discipline Skills – Digital Architect for Level 1 and Level 2

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 1	Skill Level 2
DAS01	Scoping Digital Transformation	Engage with business stakeholders to discover and define the initial scope and business objectives for a Digital Transformation.	Digital Architects work with C-level executive teams and other stakeholders to scope and define transformational change using new business models, organization and team structures, and innovative technology.	Applied	Deep
DAS02	Outside-in Design	Apply outside-in design approaches in the development of a solution or product.	Digital Architects must be able to apply outside-in design approaches using non-linear thinking techniques – for example, Design Thinking, TRIZ, lateral thinking, CPS – to the development of products or solutions.	Applied	Deep
DAS03	Incremental Validation	Implement strategies and plans to validate that new and modified requirements are tracked and incrementally added.	Digital Architects need to ensure that new, validated requirements can be incrementally added (or clarified) with rapid, incremental releases and tracked in a change control and requirements backlog process, so that, changes can be documented, prioritized, and held for a future design release.	Applied	Deep
DAS04	Digital Assurance	Implement strategies and plans to assure that the desired business outcome is being achieved as a result of the Digital Transformation initiatives adopted.	Digital Architects are responsible for determining whether the objectives of the Digital Transformation project are being met throughout the lifecycle of the digital enterprise.	Apply	Deep

3.5 Experience Profile Requirements

An Experience Profile is a coherent written description of a project or architectural engagement (for example, Enterprise Architecture, Solution Architecture, or Architectural Framework) that provides a Candidate with the opportunity to show how they perform as an Open Certified Architect, and enables a Peer Review Board to understand and question the Candidate's thought processes and decisions.

Each Experience Profile must describe a project completed not more than eight (8) years preceding the submission of the Milestone Application to the Certification Authority. At least one (1) of the Experience Profiles must describe a project completed not more than three (3) years preceding the submission of the Milestone Application to the Certification Authority.

Projects over two (2) years long may be used for multiple Experience Profiles under either of the following conditions:

- **The project had clearly-defined work efforts which took place in parallel, each with their own solution development and design activities and their own deliverables**
- **The project had clearly-defined phases that were executed in succession, each with its own solution development and design activities and deliverables**

Note that a second project phase that constructs and implements the solution developed by the first phase does not meet this requirement.

In either case, each profiled project entity must meet all of the Experience Profile criteria defined in Table 7 below.

Each Experience Profile must include:

- A description of the business purpose of the project
- A concise description of the project
- The Candidate's role
- The Candidate's period of involvement

Table 7 defines the attributes that must be present within Experience Profiles for Level 1 or Level 2 certification and against which the Experience Profiles will be evaluated.

Table 7: Required Attributes for Experience Profiles for Level 1 and Level 2

Ref.	Experience	Description	Rationale	Level 1	Level 2
EXP01	Successfully Architecting	Demonstrated success.	Open Certified Architects are expected to be repeatedly successful in architecting solutions that have been used in their implementation. Successful means that the Candidate's architectural artifacts were used, or could have been used, in the implementation of the solution or component.	Candidates must have participated in the role of Architect on a successful architectural engagement or project.	Candidates must have performed in the role of lead Architect on a successful architectural engagement or project that met its acceptance criteria.
EXP02	Leading	Performed as a lead Architect.	Open Certified Architects are expected to lead the development of architectural deliverables.	Not applicable to this level of certification.	Candidates must have performed as a lead Architect in the development of a major project or subsystem.
EXP03	Project Complexity	Demonstrated experience in complex architectural engagements.	Open Certified Architects have experience in complex architectural engagements. Complexity may apply to the business problem, the context, the solution, etc.	Candidates must have participated in the role of Architect on a complex architectural engagement or project.	Candidates must have performed as a lead Architect on a complex architectural engagement or project.
EXP04	Architecture Discipline	Demonstrated experience in the architecture discipline.	Open Certified Architects must have experience in their architecture discipline.	Candidates must have participated in the role of Architect on a <discipline-specific> engagement or project.	Candidates must have performed as an Architect in a lead role in a <discipline-specific> engagement or project.

3.6 Professional Development Requirements

Table 8 lists the Professional Development requirements for Level 1 and Level 2.

To achieve certification Candidates must be able to demonstrate that they have met the following requirements.

Table 8: Professional Development Requirements for Level 1 and Level 2

Ref.	Development	Description	Rationale	Development Level 1	Development Level 2
PD01	Training in the Discipline of Architecture	Candidates must have completed formal training in the discipline of architecture (i.e., methods/frameworks for designing and defining <discipline-specific> architectures), either through attendance at a taught course, or through self-study.	Open Certified Architects are expected to have undergone at least a basic level of training in their discipline. The Program is intentionally not specific about the nature of the training expected because of the evolving nature of the body of knowledge and the profession.	Attendance at a taught course, or through self-study.	Attendance at a taught course, or through self-study.
PD02	Knowledge of Technology Trends and Techniques	Candidates are required to develop and maintain their knowledge of the technology trends and techniques that are relevant to developing solutions for solving business problems.	Open Certified Architects are expected to develop and maintain an understanding of the technology trends and techniques so that they can leverage that body of knowledge into feasible solutions.	Develop and maintain personal knowledge.	Maintain personal knowledge within the last year.

Ref.	Development	Description	Rationale	Development Level 1	Development Level 2
PD03	Knowledge of Vertical Industry Sectors (e.g., telecoms, financial, etc.)	Candidates are required to develop and maintain an understanding of their client's business as it pertains to their client's vertical industry (e.g., telecoms, financial, etc.). Candidates should endeavor to sustain this learning process during the time they are engaged with a client or produce architectures that are industry-specific.	Open Certified Architects are expected to develop and maintain an understanding of their client's business as it pertains to their client's vertical industry (e.g., telecoms, financial, etc.). Open Certified Architects are expected to stay up-to-date with developments in their client's industry sector in order to ensure the solutions they define are appropriate to the current and future business context.	Develop and maintain personal knowledge.	Maintain personal knowledge.
PD04	Skills and Knowledge in Architecture Disciplines	Candidates are required to develop and maintain their skills and knowledge in <discipline-specific> architecture.	Open Certified Architects are expected to continue to develop their skills and to stay up-to-date with the development of their profession.	Maintain personal skills and knowledge.	Maintain personal skills and knowledge.

3.7 Community Contribution Requirements

Table 9 lists the Community Contribution requirements for Level 1 and Level 2.

To achieve certification Candidates must be able to demonstrate that they have met the following requirements.

Table 9: Community Contribution Requirements for Level 1 and Level 2

Ref.	Contribution	Description	Rationale	Contribution Level 1	Contribution Level 2
CC01	Contribution to the Architecture Profession	Candidates must make contributions to the architecture profession; for example, publications, teaching, mentoring, research collaboration, or participation in professional organizations.	Open Certified Architects are expected to contribute to the growth and vitality of their profession.	None	Contribute to the profession. Mentoring people in their career progression as Architects is required.

3.8 Experience Requirements

Table 10 lists the Experience requirements for Level 1 and Level 2.

To achieve certification Candidates must be able to demonstrate that they have at least the following experience.

Table 10: Experience Requirements for Level 1 and Level 2

Ref.	Experience	Description	Rationale	Experience Level 1	Experience Level 2
EC01	Developing Architectures	Experience of developing the architectural aspects of one or more <discipline-specific> projects or engagements for at least the specified number of months of full-time equivalent engagement.	Open Certified Architects must demonstrate a minimum period of experience in performing as an architect.	At least 24 months, possibly with supervision such as mentoring.	At least 36 months, with accountability for the architectural aspects.
EC02	Architectural Complexity	Experience producing architectures that: 1. Involve the application and integration of a number of dimensions (products, technologies, services, processes,	Open Certified Architects have a variety of experiences that demonstrate their ability to successfully deliver solutions to complex problems. For Business Architects, this could involve business'	Architectural complexity is demonstrated across more than one (1) dimension or domain.	Architectural complexity is demonstrated across at least four (4) dimensions or domains.

Ref.	Experience	Description	Rationale	Experience Level 1	Experience Level 2
		management, security, governance, etc.) and/or domains (Business, Data, Information, Application, Technology, Security, Integration, etc.) from either the business, digital, enterprise, or solution perspective. 2. Encompass functional components together with non-functional or operational components.	strategic intent (e.g., business vision, mission, business logic, ambition) with some operational aspects (e.g., people, process, technology, management). For other architecture disciplines, this could involve the application and integration of different products, technologies, and services, or domains (Business, Application, Infrastructure, and Information).		

Ref.	Experience	Description	Rationale	Experience Level 1	Experience Level 2
EC03	Different Types of Technologies and Architectures	Experience producing solutions/business-related change that involves different types of technologies and architectures.	Open Certified Architects have had exposure working with different technologies and architectures. Through this experience (not necessarily an architecture engagement), an Open Certified Architect can make the decisions that most appropriately satisfy requirements and mitigate risks to the project. For Business Architects, this could involve experience with applying different types of technologies and architectures to realize business capabilities in transport, manufacturing, or utilities, for example. For other architecture disciplines, this could involve experience with multiple types of systems/application architectures, and multiple hardware and software platforms.	Exposure is demonstrated to more than one (1) type of technology and/or architecture.	Exposure is demonstrated to more than one (1) type of technology and more than one (1) type of architecture.
EC04	Architecting Workable Solutions	Candidates must demonstrate an understanding of their architectural decisions and their impact on solutions that have been realized in a project or engagement.	Open Certified Architects must be able to apply knowledge gained from inception to deployment of a solution in order to architect viable/feasible solutions; i.e., are able to avoid hypothetical architectures that cannot be practically realized.	Evidence that demonstrates the Candidate's appreciation of the impact of their architectural decisions on the realization and operation of a solution.	Evidence that demonstrates the Candidate's understanding of the impact of their architectural decisions on the realization and operation of a solution.

Ref.	Experience	Description	Rationale	Experience Level 1	Experience Level 2
EC05	Industry Sector(s)	Candidates must have demonstrated expertise in one or more industry sectors, including the business, legal, and regulatory context.	Open Certified Architects need to have broad, up-to-date, and relevant expertise in the industry sectors in which they work, and must have applied that knowledge.	Activity is required in one or more industry sectors.	Activity is required in one or more industry sectors.
EC06	Significant Information Communication Technology (ICT) Trends	Candidates must have demonstrated knowledge of significant trends in ICT.	Open Certified Architects need to have broad, up-to-date, and relevant expertise in significant ICT trends and possess the ability to apply those trends to architectural decisions.	Activity is required with one or more significant ICT trends.	Activity is required with one or more significant ICT trends.
EC07	Full Lifecycle Involvement	Experience with strategy/design/implementation aspects of solution.	Open Certified Architects are expected to have experience with all aspects of a solution in the full lifecycle.	Candidate's experience must include the understanding and appreciation of the solution lifecycle from strategy, design, and implementation through to completion, enabling the Architect to produce solution designs that are successful.	Candidate's experience must include the solution lifecycle from strategy, design, and implementation through to completion, enabling the Architect to produce solution designs that are successful.

4. Level 3 Conformance Requirements (Normative)

The Conformance Requirements for a Level 3 Open Certified Architect are broken down as follows:

- Core Foundation skills
- Experience Profile requirements
- Professional Development requirements
- Community Contribution requirements
- Experience requirements

4.1 Core Foundation Skills

Table 11 lists the Core Foundation skills for Level 3.

To achieve certification Candidates must be able to document that they have demonstrated these skills at the required level (or higher) repeatedly and successfully.

Level 3 conformance criteria are a combination of skills and experiences expected by a practitioner who has proven their ability to advance the state-of-the-art and practice within their Profession. This implies a professional who has significant breadth and depth of impact on the business through the application of their Profession. They are expected to have met the defined Level 3 criteria. As such, the skill proficiency for each of the Level 3 conformance criteria must be fully met at the Deep Skill level. Level 3 (Distinguished) skills and conformance criteria are not extensions of those defined at Level 2, but are different in nature and are specifically defined to support the leadership expectations of an executive-practitioner capable of advancing the state-of-the-art.

Table 11: Core Foundation Skills for Level 3

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 3
DCFS01	Employ Collaborative Influence	Facilitate the implementation of an important business initiative by promoting teaming and cross-organizational participation.	Distinguished Architects achieve results that require support and collaboration of disparate groups with potentially conflicting interests.	Deep
DCFS02	Employ Cross-Organizational Leadership	Initiate, lead, and influence multi-disciplinary initiatives across organizational boundaries coordinating the activities necessary to succeed.	Distinguished Architects lead successful business transformations that involve multiple disciplines across organizational boundaries.	Deep
DCFS03	Manage Risks	Guide an organization's strategy to recognize and mitigate the weaknesses or exposures in their plans and implementations in a way that secures successful and sustainable outcomes.	Distinguished Architects detect and mitigate risks that jeopardize the business's initiatives, compliance, and/or organizations at an enterprise scale.	Deep

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 3
DCFS04	Develop Strategic Plans	Identify and drive strategic architectural decisions and plans for an enterprise.	Distinguished Architects are responsible for driving decisions and plans that affect the strategy of an enterprise.	Deep
DCFS05	Manage Cross-Organizational Projects	Allocate project activities and architecture assignments from multiple projects to multiple teams of architects, across multiple organizational units.	Distinguished Architects can architect and manage complex projects that involve multiple organizational units and multiple teams of architects.	Deep
DCFS06	Communicate on an Executive Level	Communicate architectures and strategies to business and/or project/program executives in a way that is appropriate and gains their commitment.	Distinguished Architects communicate in a manner that convinces at the executive level.	Deep
DCFS07	Advocate Stakeholders' Interests	Simultaneous advocate of multiple stakeholders' interests.	Distinguished Architects understand and advocate the various, and potentially conflicting, interests and views of multiple stakeholders.	Deep
DCFS08	Engage Architecture Thinking at Strategic Levels	Apply architectural thinking at a strategic level (vision, mission, strategy, etc.) to deliver positive impact and results to the business.	Distinguished Architects apply holistic and strategic thinking for the enterprise in order to identify opportunities that deliver significant positive business impact.	Deep
DCFS09	Troubleshooting and Remediation	Perform architectural troubleshooting and provide remediation leadership and guidance for architectures or solutions.	Distinguished Architects identify problems in troubled architectures or solutions and provide leadership and guidance in resolving them.	Deep
DCFS10	Technology Innovation	Provide breakthrough innovation in the use of technology to deliver greater business value.	Distinguished Architects innovate in the use of technology to deliver business value to their clients.	Deep
DCFS11	Establish Governance	Establish and maintain processes and policies for governance in those programs or projects for which the architect is responsible.	Distinguished Architects establish and maintain processes and policies for governing the architectures of the projects and programs for which they are responsible.	Deep

Ref.	Skill	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 3
DCFS12	Set Metrics for Compliance	Establish metrics for validating the conformance of an implementation to an architecture.	Distinguished Architects select and/or create metrics that are appropriate for assessing compliance of implementations to their architecture.	Deep
DCFS13	Assess Architectures & Implementations	Evaluate the relevance and currency of implementations and architectures in a changing business and technology environment.	Distinguished Architects analyze how a changing business and technology environment may impact current and future architectures and implementations.	Deep

4.2 Experience Profile Requirements

An Experience Profile is a coherent written description of a project or architectural engagement (for example, Enterprise Architecture, Solution Architecture, or Architectural Framework) that provides a Candidate with the opportunity to show how they perform as a Distinguished Architect, and enables a Peer Review Board to understand and question the Candidate's thought processes and decisions.

Each Experience Profile must describe a project completed not more than eight (8) years preceding the submission of the Milestone Application to the Certification Authority. At least one (1) of the Experience Profiles must describe a project completed not more than three (3) years preceding the submission of the Milestone Application to the Certification Authority.

Projects over two (2) years long may be used for multiple Experience Profiles under either of the following conditions:

- **The project had clearly-defined work efforts which took place in parallel, each with their own solution development and design activities and their own deliverables**
- **The project had clearly-defined phases that were executed in succession, each with its own solution development and design activities and deliverables**

Note that a second project phase that constructs and implements the solution developed by the first phase does not meet this requirement.

In either case, each profiled project entity must meet all of the Experience Profile criteria defined in Table 12 below.

Each Experience Profile must include:

- A description of the business purpose of the project
- A concise description of the project
- The Candidate's role
- The Candidate's period of involvement

Table 12 defines the attributes that must be present within Experience Profiles for Level 3 certification and against which the Experience Profiles will be evaluated.

Table 12: Required Attributes for Experience Profiles for Level 3

Ref.	Experience	Description	Rationale	Skill Level 3
DEXP01	Leading Successful Significantly Complex Projects	Distinguished Architects have repeated experience successfully directing significantly complex architecture initiatives.	Distinguished Architects have experience with developing solutions that typically involve different stakeholders, multiple lines of business, many solution varieties, highly regulated environments, (de)mergers, acquisitions, business transformations, international and/or global scale, etc.	The Candidate must explain why the project was significantly complex, as measured within their corporate industrial and operational environment, and how their involvement was essential to the success of the project.
DEXP02	Leading Successful Projects with Significant Business Impact	Distinguished Architects have repeated experience successfully directing projects that significantly positively and measurably affect the business.	Distinguished Architects have experience with developing solutions that result in significant positive business value and/or impact.	The Candidate must explain why the project was successful and how it impacted the business significantly, as measured within their corporate industrial and operational environment, and how their involvement was essential to the success of the project.
DEXP03	Driving Significant Strategic Enterprise Initiatives	Distinguished Architects have repeated experience in setting and driving architecture goals and objectives for significant strategic enterprise initiatives.	Distinguished Architects provide thought leadership towards directing and delivering the mission of the organization.	The Candidate must explain how they drove a strategic enterprise initiative that was significant within their corporate industrial and operational environment, and how their involvement was essential to the success of that initiative.

4.3 Professional Development Requirements

Table 13 lists the Professional Development requirements for Level 3.

To achieve certification Candidates must be able to demonstrate that they have met the following requirements.

Table 13: Professional Development Requirements for Level 3

Ref.	Development	Description	Rationale
DPD01	N/A	N/A	N/A

Ref.	Development	Description	Rationale
DPD02	Knowledge of Technology Trends and Techniques	Candidates are required to maintain their knowledge of the technology trends and techniques that are relevant to developing solutions for solving business problems.	Distinguished Architects maintain an understanding of the technology trends and techniques so that they can leverage that body of knowledge into feasible solutions.
DPD03	Knowledge of Vertical Industry Sectors (e.g., telecoms, financial, etc.)	Candidates are required to maintain an understanding of their client's business as it pertains to their client's vertical industry (e.g., telecoms, financial, etc.). Candidates should endeavor to sustain this learning process during the time they are engaged with a client or produce architectures that are industry-specific.	Distinguished Architects maintain an understanding of their client's business as it pertains to their client's vertical industry (e.g., telecoms, financial, etc.). Distinguished Architects are expected to stay up-to-date with developments in their client's industry sector in order to ensure the solutions they define are appropriate to the current and future business context.
DPD04	Skills and Knowledge in Architecture Disciplines	Candidates must continually develop their skills and knowledge of the latest architecture-related trends and techniques.	Distinguished Architects continue to develop their skills and to stay up-to-date with the development of their profession.

4.4 Community Contribution Requirements

Table 14 lists the Community Contribution requirements for Level 3.

To achieve certification Candidates must be able to demonstrate that they have met the following requirements.

Table 14: Community Contribution Requirements for Level 3

Ref.	Contribution	Description	Rationale
DCC01	Contributions to the Architecture Profession	Candidates must make contributions to the architecture profession; for example, architecture-related publications, research collaboration, development of training, or contributions to standards bodies or professional organizations.	Distinguished Architects contribute to the growth and vitality of the profession inside and outside their organization.

Ref.	Contribution	Description	Rationale
DCC02	Development of Professional Architects	Candidates are expected to develop professional architects through teaching, serving on Peer Review Boards, coaching, and/or mentoring.	Distinguished Architects transfer knowledge and experience to the architecture community.

4.5 Experience Requirements

Table 15 lists the Experience requirements for Level 3.

To achieve certification Candidates must be able to demonstrate that they have at least the following experience.

Table 15: Experience Requirements for Level 3

Ref.	Experience	Description	Rationale
DEC01	Establish Architectural Vision	Establish architectural vision for complex architectures.	Distinguished Architects realize architectural strategies that are complex. Complex here refers to engagements that concern, for example, many different stakeholders, multiple lines of business, many solution varieties, highly regulated environments, (de)mergers, acquisitions, business transformations, international and/or global scale, etc.
DEC02	Innovative Leadership	Lead with impact successfully introducing innovations in strategic projects, programs, or initiatives.	Distinguished Architects anticipate, create, and define concepts in engagements that lead to innovations, radical thought, (business/operational) shifts, (strategy) changes, breakthroughs, etc.
DEC03	Demonstrate Business Impact	The Candidate must have demonstrated positive significant impact on the business through a complex project or initiative.	Distinguished Architects demonstrate measureable positive significant impact on the business outcome through complex projects or initiatives. The Candidate must have demonstrated this through financial or other KPIs.
DEC04	Establish Architectural Process, Policies, and Procedures	The Candidate must have experience defining architectural processes, policies, and procedures that impact multiple projects and/or business areas.	Distinguished Architects establish architectural processes, policies, and procedures that have a significant impact beyond a single project or initiative. This includes, but is not limited to, selecting and adapting the proper architectural methods, governance, and technical standards.

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